CHECKLIST FROM @DOMBUILDS.AI

The Boring Rejection Killer

A pre-submit checklist that catches the common App Store rejection reasons before Apple's reviewer does.

> Most rejections are not about your idea. They are about a reviewer who could not log in, could not find a price, or could not tell why you need the camera, so this list makes you review your own app first.

Use it in 5 minutes

1. Install your release build fresh on a real device and open this list next to it.
2. Go section by section and tick only what you actually checked on screen, not what you remember building.
3. Paste the fixed review notes into App Store Connect, then submit.

TEST IT LIKE A STRANGER

01 **Fresh install, release build**
Delete the app, install the TestFlight build, and go through onboarding as a new user. Debug builds hide crashes and missing config that the reviewer will hit first (Guideline 2.1).

02 **Kill the placeholder content**
Search your app for lorem ipsum, test data, empty screens and buttons that do nothing. Unfinished features read as an incomplete app (Guideline 2.1).

03 **Remove beta and demo labels**
No 'beta', 'coming soon' or 'test version' text inside the app or the listing. App Store builds must be final versions, and TestFlight exists for betas (Guideline 2.2).

04 **Try it on an iPad**
Even an iPhone only app can run on iPad, and the reviewer may test there. Check that no screen is cut off, overlapped or impossible to tap.

05 **Turn off Wi-Fi once**

Open the app offline. Show a clear message instead of a blank screen or a frozen spinner, because an app that looks broken gets rejected as broken.

LET THE REVIEWER IN

06 **Working demo account in the notes**

Add a username and password in App Review Information that works right now and already has sample data. Log in with it yourself the day you submit.

07 **Explain what is not obvious**

If a feature needs a QR code, a second device, a location or hardware, say how to reach it or attach a short video link. Reviewers do not guess.

08 **Write notes for a 2 minute read**

Short notes the reviewer can scan: what the app does, where the paid feature is, where account deletion lives, what permissions it asks for and why. See the template below.

MONEY SCREENS

09 **Price is the biggest text on the paywall**

Show the full billed amount and period, like '$29.99 per year' (example). A tiny price under a big 'per week' number or a giant free trial button invites a 3.1.2 rejection.

10 **Terms, Privacy and Restore on the paywall**

Add tappable links to your Terms of Use and Privacy Policy, plus a Restore Purchases button that actually works with a sandbox account.

11 **Digital stuff goes through in-app purchase**

If you unlock features, content or credits inside the app, use Apple's in-app purchase. Pointing users to buy on your website can be rejected under 3.1.1, depending on your region's current rules.

12 **Products are attached and approved**

In App Store Connect, add your in-app purchases or subscriptions to this version. If they are not submitted with the build, the reviewer sees an empty or broken paywall.

PRIVACY AND PERMISSIONS

13 **Purpose strings that say why**

Each permission text names the feature: 'Camera is used to scan receipts so you can log expenses.' Generic text like 'We need camera access' gets flagged under 5.1.1.

14 **Ask only when the feature needs it**

Request camera, location or contacts at the moment the user taps the related feature, not all at launch. Also make sure a 'No' does not lock up the app.

15 **Delete account inside the app**

If users can create an account, they must be able to delete it from inside the app, not just by email. Put it in Settings where the reviewer will look (5.1.1(v)).

16 **Login option beyond Google only**

If you offer a third party login like Google, also offer a privacy focused option. Sign in with Apple is the simplest way to meet Guideline 4.8.

17 **Privacy labels match reality**

Compare your App Privacy answers with every SDK you ship: analytics, crash reporting, ads, AI APIs. If something tracks across apps, show the App Tracking Transparency prompt first.

18 **Privacy Policy link works**

Open the policy URL in App Store Connect and inside the app. It must load, belong to your app, and mention what data you collect, including data sent to AI services.

STORE LISTING

19 **Screenshots show the real app**

Use actual screens with the core feature working. A logo, a splash screen or only marketing slogans fail Guideline 2.3. Captions are fine on top of real UI.

20 **Prove it is more than a website**

If the app wraps a web view, add something native that matters: widgets, notifications, offline mode, or Share Sheet. Repackaged websites fall under 4.2 minimum functionality.

21 **No other platforms in the metadata**

Remove words like 'also on Android' or other store names from description and screenshots. Irrelevant platform mentions are flagged under 2.3.10.

22 **Support URL is a real page**

The Support URL must open a page with a way to contact you. A homepage with no contact info or a dead link is an easy rejection.

23 **Age rating answered honestly**

If your app has user generated content or open AI chat, answer the questionnaire to match. Apps with user content also need reporting and blocking tools (Guideline 1.2).

IF IT STILL GETS REJECTED

24 **Read the guideline number first**

The number in the message tells you which section above to fix. Read the full guideline text on Apple's site before changing anything.

25 **Reply when it is a misunderstanding**

If the feature already exists, reply in App Review with exact steps or a screenshot instead of uploading a new build. Polite, specific, one paragraph.

26 **Fix every point in one build**

If the message lists several issues, fix all of them before resubmitting, and say in the notes what changed for each guideline number.

REVIEW NOTES, BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Please review my app. Thanks!

After: Receipt Tracker scans paper receipts and logs expenses. Demo login: review@example.com / Review2026 (has sample data). Paywall: Settings > Upgrade. Account deletion: Settings > Account > Delete Account. Camera is only requested when you tap Scan. Sign in with Apple is available on the login screen.

Next

I post more of what I learn shipping my own apps with AI on @dombuilds.ai, including the fixes that got them approved.

Follow @dombuilds.ai for the next one.